Counterargument, Concessions and Rebuttals

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What is a counterargument?

- A **counterargument** is an argument opposed to your thesis or part of your thesis. It expresses the view of a person who disagrees with your position. It will contain at least one reason and an explicit or implicit opinion.
- It can also be called a counterclaim.

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Why is a counterargument important?

- **Addressing the claims of the opposition is an important component in building a convincing argument.**
- **It demonstrates your credibility as a writer- you have researched multiple sides of the argument and have come to an informed decision.**
- **It shows you have considered other points of view-- that other points of view are valid and reasonable.**

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Example1: Where is the Counterargument?

State DOE officials believe that standardized testing is good because it provides a way of measuring ALL students by using the same standard test. It is true that using a standardized test is a more efficient way to measure all students. However, these officials fail to consider that not all students can and should be measured in the same manner.

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Example 2: Where is the Counterargument?

Due to the unavoidable distraction, students should not have headphones on when their teachers are giving a lesson. Sure, students can use headphones to block out their teachers during class. However, when every member of the class is working individually after important information has been given, listening to music can be a helpful learning tool. It would create a more relaxing, calm environment for learning.

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Example 3: Where is the Counterargument?

With additional incentives to purchase electric vehicles, the government would be promoting energy-efficiency, cleaner air, and reduced dependence on fossil fuels. Of course, these incentives would reduce our dependence on fossil fuels, but one of the reasons why so many people live in the United States is because of the freedom of choice…

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How to begin a Counterargument

Negative attitude
- It is a popular misconception

Neutral attitude
- Some people may that…

Positive attitude
- Some people may that… + concession

These transitions signal opposition

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What is a concession?

- **A Concession is when the writer acknowledges or recognizes a claim made by the opposition, allowing that it has some merit.**
- **A writer's goal is persuade and the audience is more likely to listen if the writer takes into account and values their perspective.**

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Why is a concession important?

- The writer demonstrates that he sees and appreciates good reasoning on the part of the opposition.
- He recognizes the validity of the opposition, but then proves the superiority of his position.
- The opposition might be right, but the writer is "more" right.

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Why is a concession important?

- Remember that a concession is not a form of weakness.
- In fact, a concession is a strength as it finds common ground with the opposition and establishes an ethical appeal: the writer is a reasonable person willing to listen to/acknowledge that there are multiple sides to an issue

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How to begin a Concession…

- It is true that…
- Certainly…
- Admittedly…
- Of course…
- Obviously…
- Sure…

These transitions signal agreement

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What is a Rebuttal?

- Your response to the Concession (the opposition's position).
- This is the 'punch' back that your thesis is right and their concession is wrong!

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Example 2: Where is the Rebuttal?

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How to begin a Rebuttal

- ……however….
- …but…in short…
- …on the other hand…so…
- …nevertheless…as a result…
- …on the contrary…
- …however…in addition…

These transitions signal contrast

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